

Datum Atlas Guide

Choose materials with property charts and indices, check their life and how to make them, step by step.

Datum Atlas 0.3.3 · 2026-11-11
github.com/Edgar-Mendonca/Datum-Atlas

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Welcome

Datum Atlas helps you choose a material and show why it is the right one. Every material is drawn on property charts as a bubble spanning its range of values; design goals and performance indices turn what the part must do into a line on the chart; limits, lines, boxes and shapes narrow the field; and the materials that pass are ranked, with the reason every other one fails. Then you compare the best, add up their energy and CO_2 through the product's life, find the processes that can make the part and what it costs, and print a report that documents the choice.

This guide takes you through Datum Atlas step by step. Each chapter stands on its own.

How to read this guide:

- Names in **bold** are buttons, tabs and boxes exactly as they appear in Datum Atlas.
- An arrow › is a path: **Select › Design Goal** means the **Select** tab, then the **Design Goal** button.
- Keys are shown like this: `Ctrl+K`.
- The orange numbers on the pictures match the numbered lists under them.

> **Tip.** Almost every tool has a small **?** beside it. Click it for a card that says what the tool does and how to use it. **Help › What Is This Tool?** lists them all.

About the data

Every value in Datum Atlas is compiled from open and public sources: government handbooks, open datasets, university notes, producers' own datasheets and typical textbook ranges. Each value names its source, and a ✓ marks values checked against a published datasheet; the others are drafts. A value that is not known is a gap, never a zero. The values describe generic materials: before you decide, check the supplier's data for the grade and condition you will use.

Install, update and start

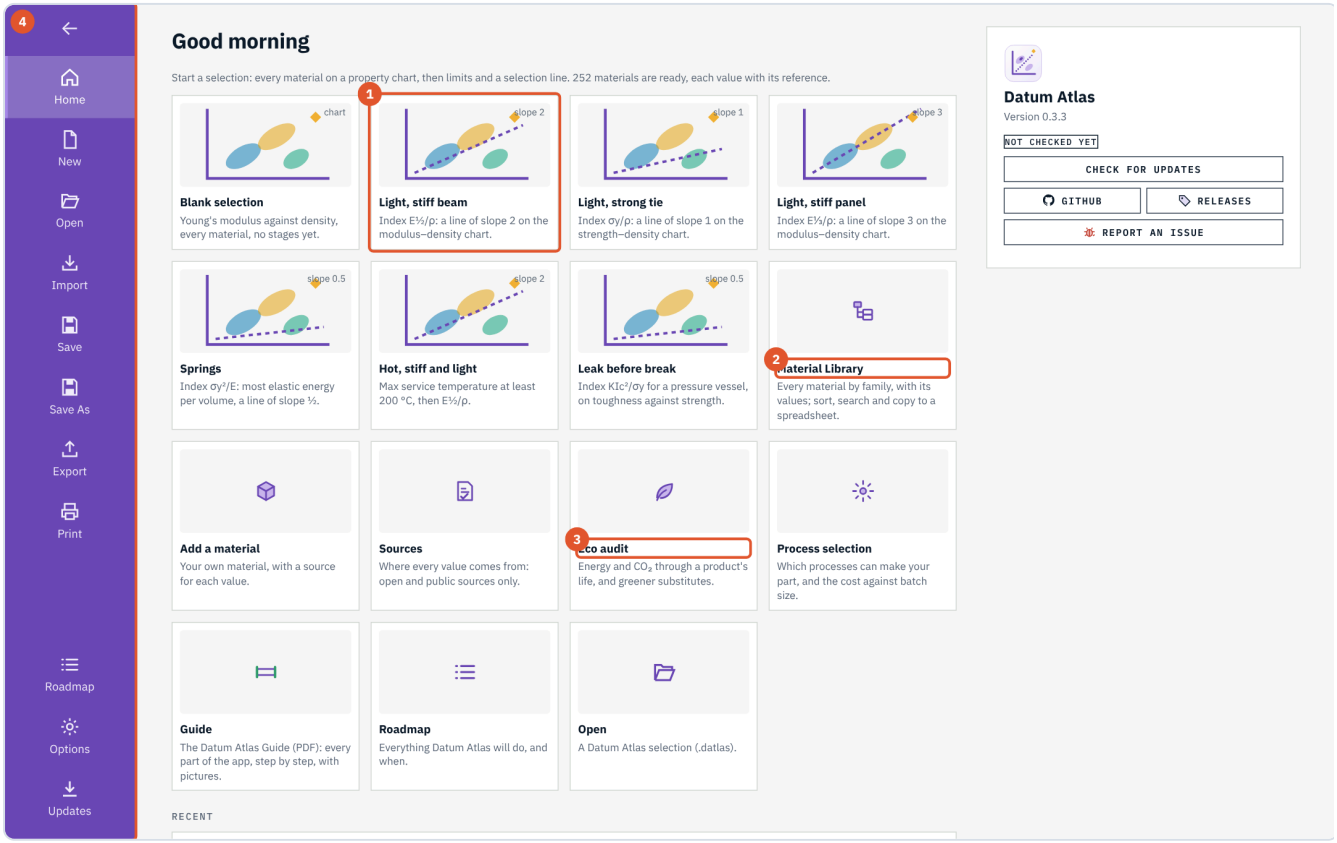
Install

1. Download `DatumAtlas-x.y.z-setup.exe` from the Releases page: github.com/Edgar-Mendonca/Datum-Atlas/releases.
2. Run it. It installs for your own Windows account, so you do not need administrator rights.
3. The first time, Windows may show **Windows protected your PC**, because the installer is not code-signed yet. Click **More info**, then **Run anyway**.

Updates

Datum Atlas checks for a new version when it starts. When one is ready, **File › Updates** shows it; click **Update now**. The download is checked against its checksum before it installs, and your projects and materials are not touched.

The Home page



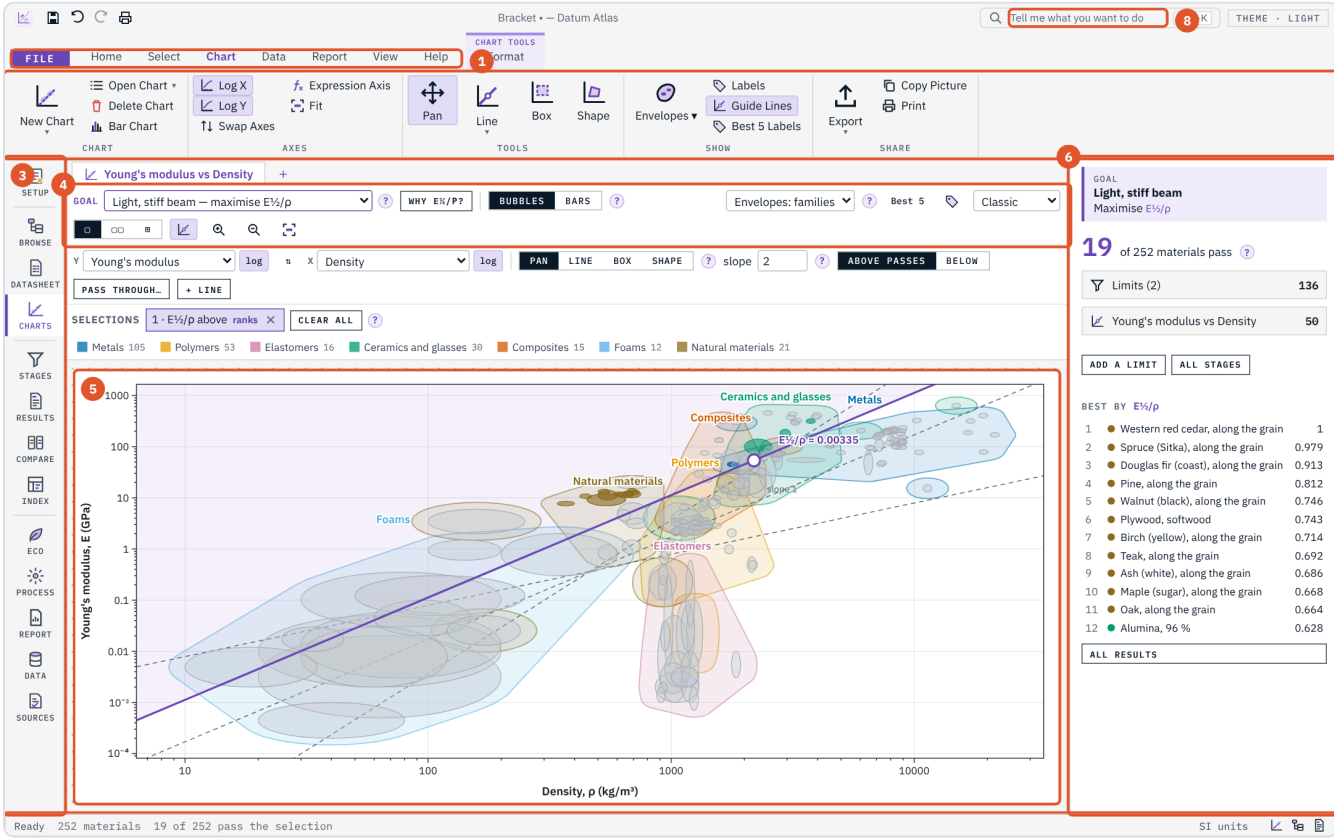
The Home page (File › Home).

1. **Design problems.** Each tile starts a project set up for a classic design: a light, stiff beam; a light, strong tie; a stiff panel; springs; a hot, stiff and light part; leak before break. **Blank selection** starts with one chart and nothing selected.
2. **Material Library** opens every material by family, with its values.

3. **Eco audit** and **Process selection** open those pages straight away.
4. **The File page** also has **New**, **Open**, **Import**, **Save**, **Save As**, **Export**, **Print**, **Roadmap**, **Options** and **Updates**. The arrow at the top goes back to your project.

Projects are saved as `.datlas` files. Your own materials live in a database of their own (`.datdb`), so every project sees them.

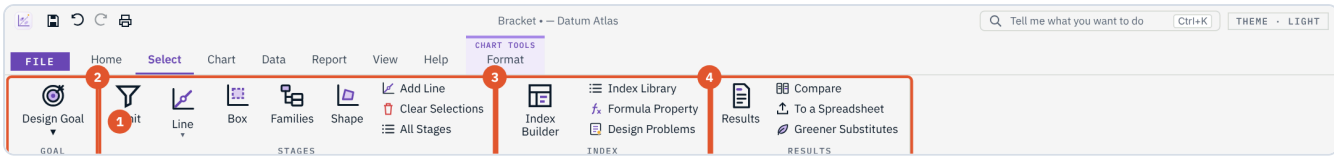
The window at a glance



The Datum Atlas window with a light, stiff beam on Young's modulus against density.

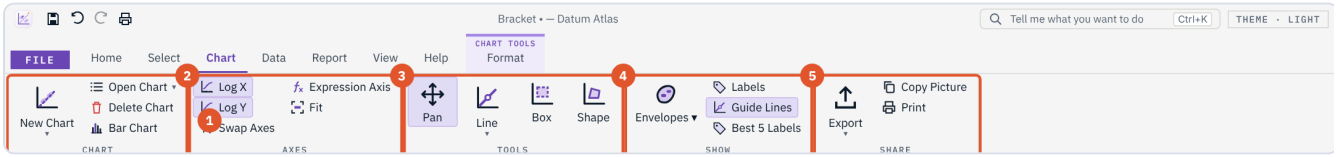
1. **File and the ribbon tabs: Home**, **Select**, **Chart**, **Data**, **Report**, **View** and **Help**. **Chart Tools › Format** appears while a chart is open.
2. **The ribbon.** The buttons of the chosen tab, in named groups.
3. **The sidebar.** One click to each page: Setup, Browse, Datasheet, Charts, Stages, Results, Compare, Index, Eco, Process, Report, Data and Sources.
4. **The chart bar.** The design goal, bubbles or bars, envelopes, the five best labelled, the chart style, the axes and the chart tools.
5. **The property chart.** Every material as a bubble; hover for its values, click to pick it, double-click for its datasheet.
6. **The stage panel.** How many materials pass, each stage with its count, and the best materials by the ranking.
7. **The status bar.** The number of materials, how many pass, the material picked, and **SI units** or **Imperial units** (click to switch).
8. **Tell Me** (`Ctrl+K`). Type what you want to do, a design goal or a material, and press `Enter`.

The ribbon at a glance:



The Select tab.

1. **Goal:** pick a design goal for the open chart.
2. **Stages:** add a limit, a selection line, a box, a shape, leave families out; add a second line; clear the selections; see all stages.
3. **Index:** the index builder and library, your own formula properties, the design problems.
4. **Results:** the ranked results, Compare, results to a spreadsheet, greener substitutes.



The Chart tab.

1. **Chart:** a new chart, open or delete one, a bar chart of one property.
2. **Axes:** log or linear scales, swap the axes, an expression axis (a formula), fit to the data.
3. **Tools:** what a drag on the chart does: pan, draw a line, a box or a shape.
4. **Show:** envelopes, labels, guide lines, the best five labelled.
5. **Share:** export the chart as a picture (SVG or PNG), copy it, print it.



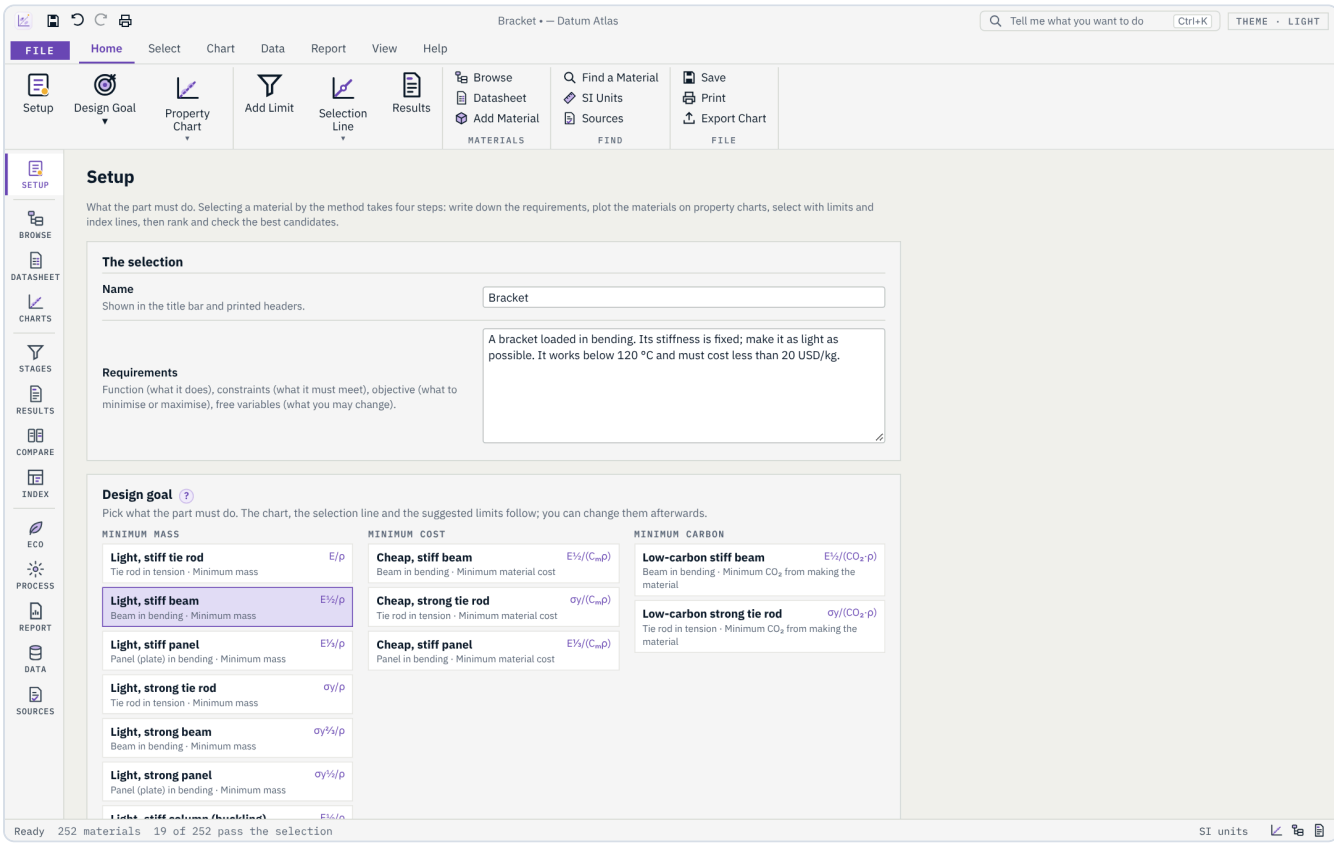
The Report tab.

1. **Compare** and the radar chart.
2. **Report:** the selection report, print, the results as a spreadsheet or CSV.
3. **Eco:** the eco audit, its charts and greener substitutes.
4. **Process:** process selection, the process records and the cost model.

The method in five steps

Datum Atlas follows the method engineers learn for choosing materials:

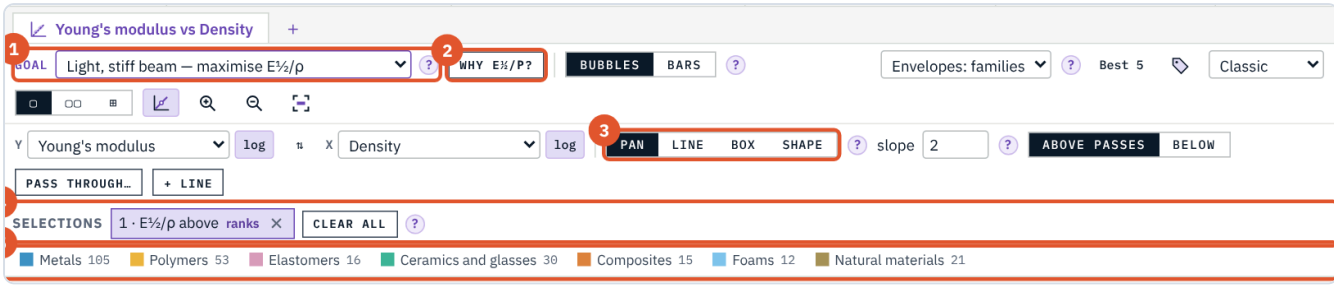
1. **Write down what the part must do.** Its *function* (carry a load in bending, hold pressure, conduct heat), its *constraints* (stiffness, strength, 150 °C, cost), its *objective* (minimise mass, cost or CO_2) and its *free variables* (what you may change: thickness, section, the material). **Setup** has a box for this.
2. **Look at the materials on a property chart.** Two properties on log axes. Each family has an envelope.
3. **Select.** Limits remove what cannot work; a selection line keeps the materials that do the job best.
4. **Rank and check.** Results lists what passes, ranked by the index, and why each other material fails. Open the datasheets of the best few and check their references.
5. **Check its life and how to make it.** The eco audit and process selection.



Setup: the requirements, the design goal and the design problems.

Property charts

A property chart puts every material on two properties: here Young's modulus against density. Each material is an ellipse spanning its range of both values, so a material whose stiffness varies with grade is a tall bubble. Each family (metals, polymers, elastomers, ceramics and glasses, composites, foams, natural materials) has a coloured envelope around its members. Log axes fit materials that differ a thousand times on one chart.



The chart bar and tools.

1. **Design goal.** Sets up the chart for a goal (next chapter).
2. **Why E½/ρ?** Explains the goal's index.
3. **Pan, Line, Box, Shape.** What a drag on the chart does.
4. **Selections.** The lines, boxes and shapes on this chart, as chips: click one to edit it, × to remove it.
5. **The legend.** Click a family to hide or show it on this chart.

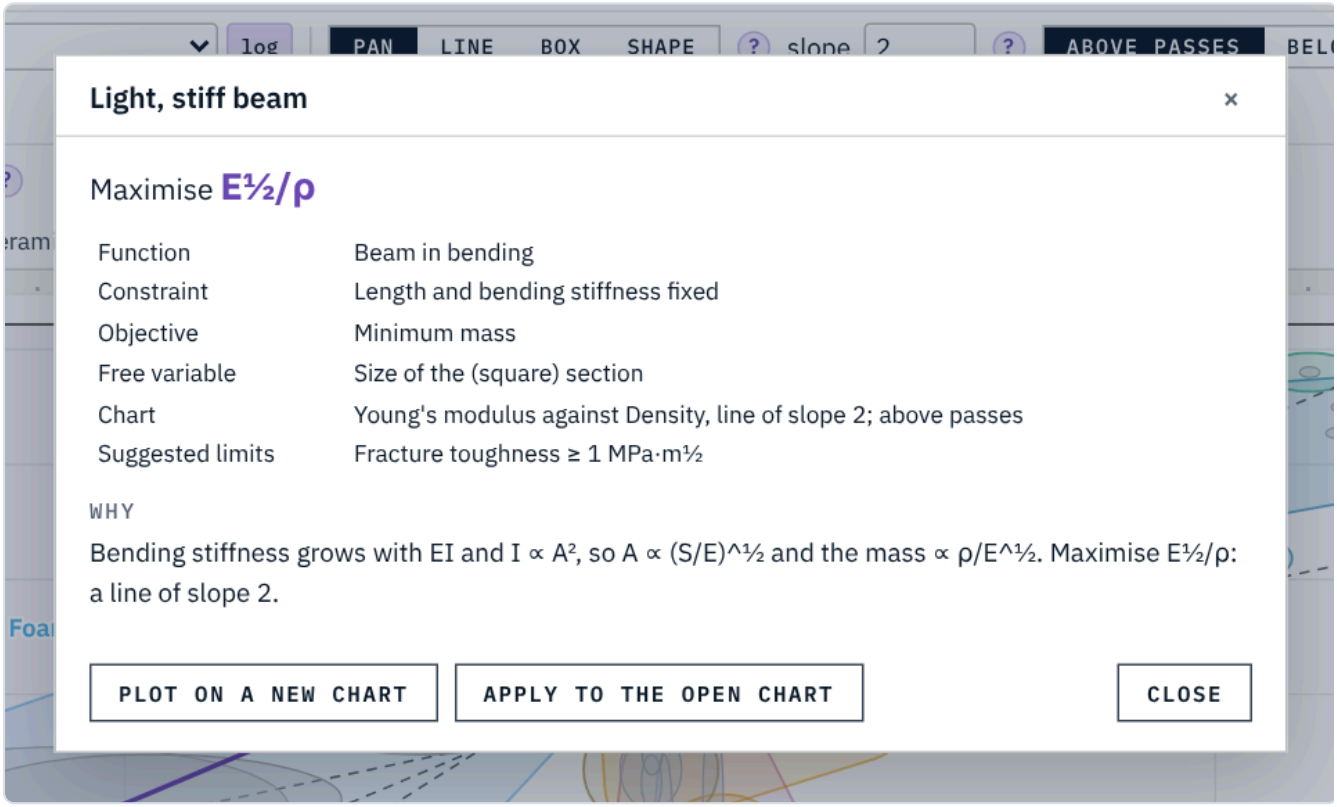
Working on the chart:

- **Hover** a bubble for its values; **click** to pick it (its datasheet shows beside the chart); **double-click** for the full datasheet.
- **Wheel** to zoom around the mouse; drag to pan with **Pan**; **Fit** shows everything.
- **Y** and **X** choose the properties; **log** switches each scale. **Expression Axis** plots a formula, such as `[E]^0.5/[rho]`.
- **Bars** draws one property for every material as a bar from its low to its high value, grouped by family.
- **Guide lines** of slope 1, 2 and 3 show the directions of the classic indices.
- **+** beside the chart tabs adds a chart. The ▢, ▢▢ and ⊞ buttons in the chart bar show one, two or four charts at once, and the material under the mouse is lit on all of them.
- **Chart style:** classic colours, publication (finer lines) or monochrome (greys, for black-and-white print).

> **Tip. Labels** names every material; **Best 5** names only the five best by the ranking. Labels move apart so they do not overlap; drag one to place it, and a leader line follows.

Design goals and performance indices

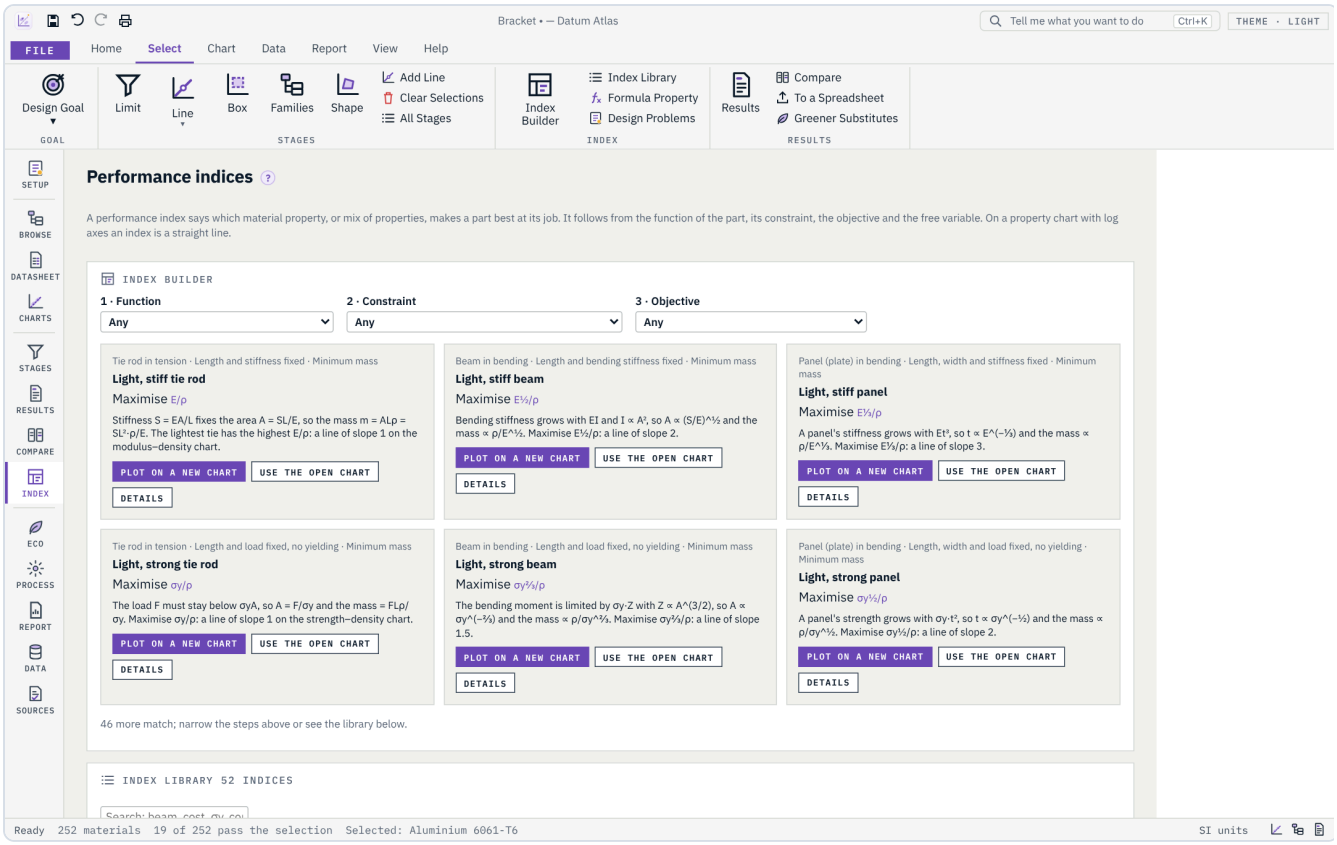
A **design goal** turns what the part must do into a line on a chart. Pick **Light, stiff beam** and Datum Atlas puts Young's modulus against density, draws a selection line of slope 2 through the best materials (the top fifth pass), adds the limits the goal needs (marked **from the goal**) and ranks the results by its index, E½/ρ.



Why E½/ρ? The function, constraint, objective and free variable behind the index.

The **index** follows from the design. A beam of fixed length and bending stiffness, made as light as possible, with its section free: its stiffness grows with E·I and I with the square of the area, so the mass falls as ρ/E½. The lightest beam has the highest E½/ρ: on log axes, a line of slope 2. A tie gives E/ρ (slope 1); a panel gives E⅓/ρ (slope 3).

There are 25 design goals, grouped: minimum mass, minimum cost, minimum carbon, elastic design, damage tolerance, thermal, and two constraints (stiff **and** strong, which set up two charts). **Explore** removes the goal's line and limits; your own limits are never touched.



The Index page: the index builder and the library.

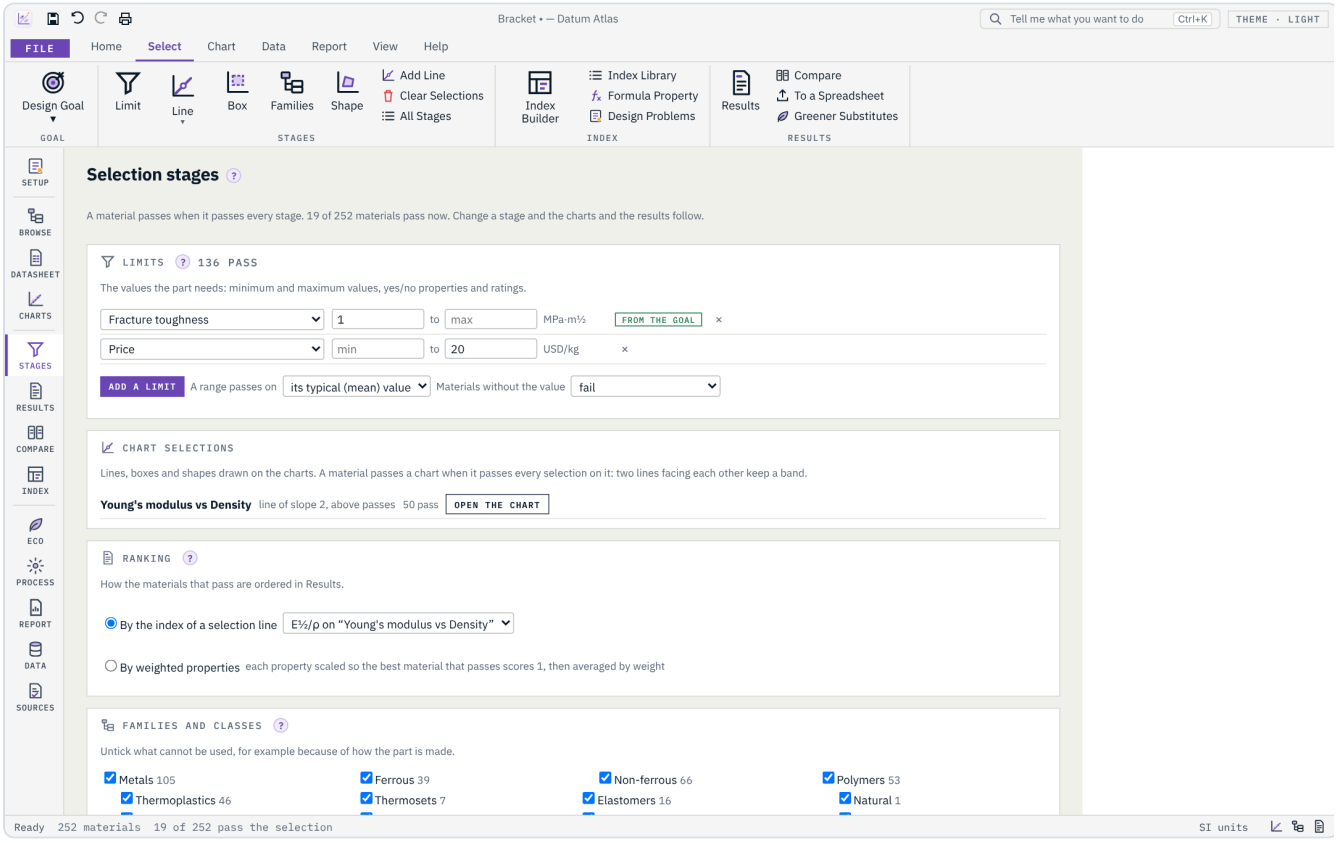
The **Index** page has 52 indices. The **Index builder** narrows them in three steps: the **function** (tie, beam, panel, column, shaft, spring, pressure vessel…), the **constraint** and the **objective**. Each card gives the index and how it follows; **Plot on a new chart** keeps the open chart, **Use the open chart** applies it there.

Your own formula properties

Data › Formula Property defines a property of your own from others, for example `[sy]^2/[E]` for a spring or `[E]*[alpha]` for thermal stress. It is worked out for every material, with its range (low with low, high with high), and works like any other property on charts, in limits and in the ranking. A material without one of the values gets a gap, never a zero.

Selecting

A material passes when it passes **every stage**.



The Stages page: limits, chart selections, ranking, and families.

Limits

Add a limit, choose a property and type a minimum, a maximum or both, in the units shown. A yes/no property (recyclable, combustible…) is a tick; a rating (fresh water, weak acids, UV light, fire resistance, castability, machinability, weldability) takes the lowest rating that will do.

- **A range passes on** its typical (mean) value, or only if the **whole range** passes.
- **Materials without the value** fail, or pass marked **no data**.

Selections on a chart

- **A line** keeps the materials above it (or below). Type its **slope**, or let a goal set it; drag its round handle, nudge it with the arrow keys, or **Pass through…** a value of the index. `Delete` removes the active selection.
- **+ Line** adds a second line. Two lines of the same slope facing each other keep a **band**.
- **Box** keeps a window of values on both properties; **Shape** draws any outline: click the corners, then click the first corner, double-click or press `Enter` to close it.

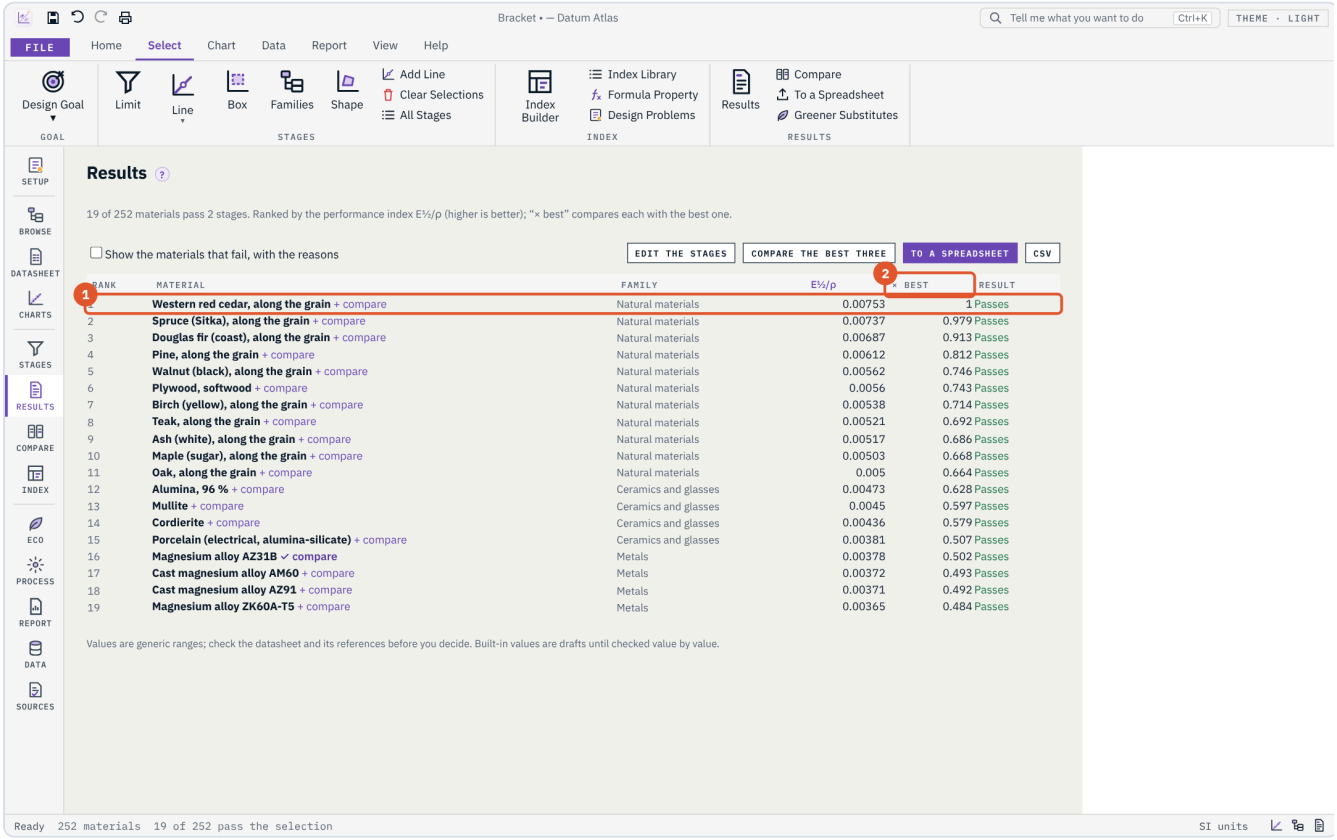
Families

Untick the families and classes that cannot be used: no polymers in a hot part, no wood where it gets wet.

Ranking

The materials that pass are ranked **by the index of a selection line**, or **by weighted properties**: choose properties, whether higher or lower is better, and a weight for each; each property is scaled so the best material that passes scores 1.

Results

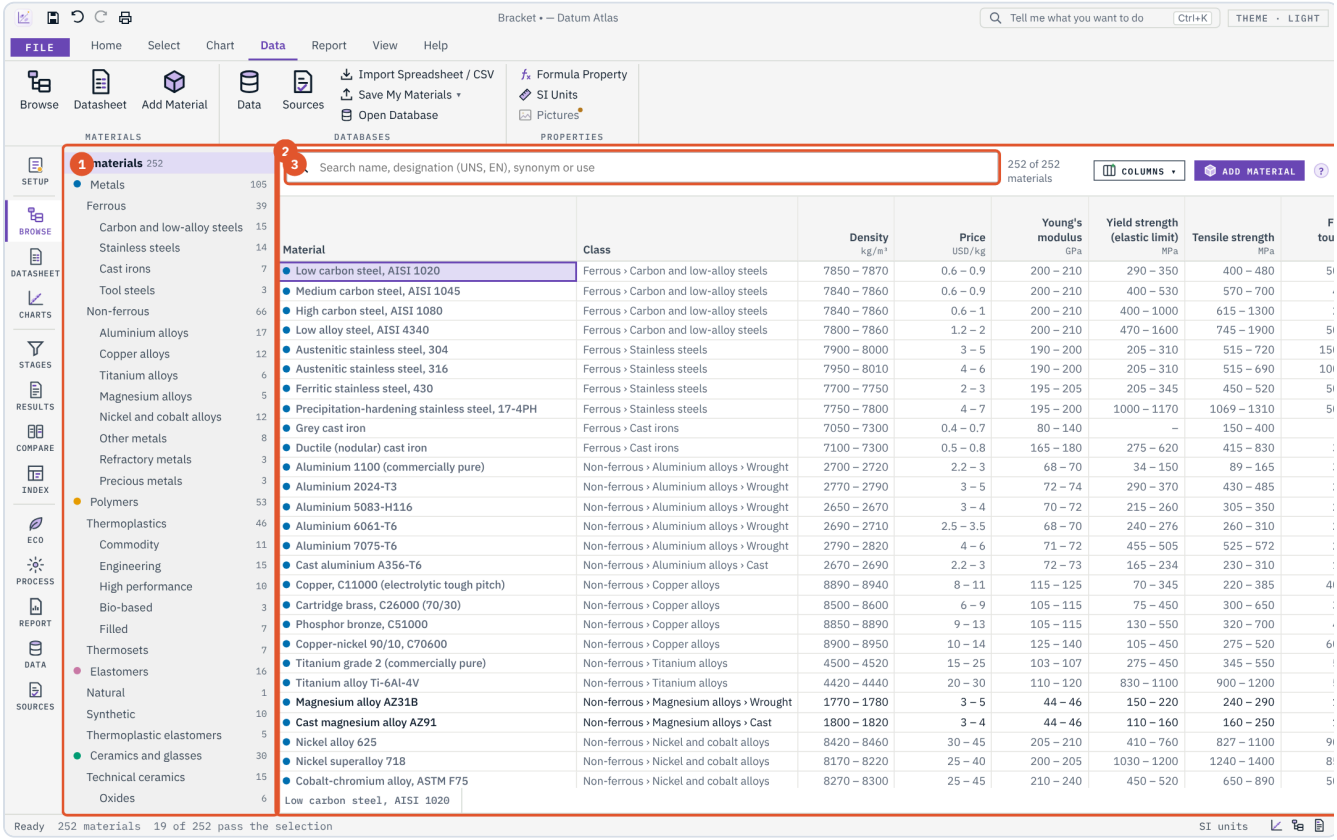


Results: every material ranked, with the reason each other one fails.

1. **The materials that pass**, ranked, with their index value.
2. **× best**: each material's index divided by the best material's: 1 for the best, 0.5 for half as good.

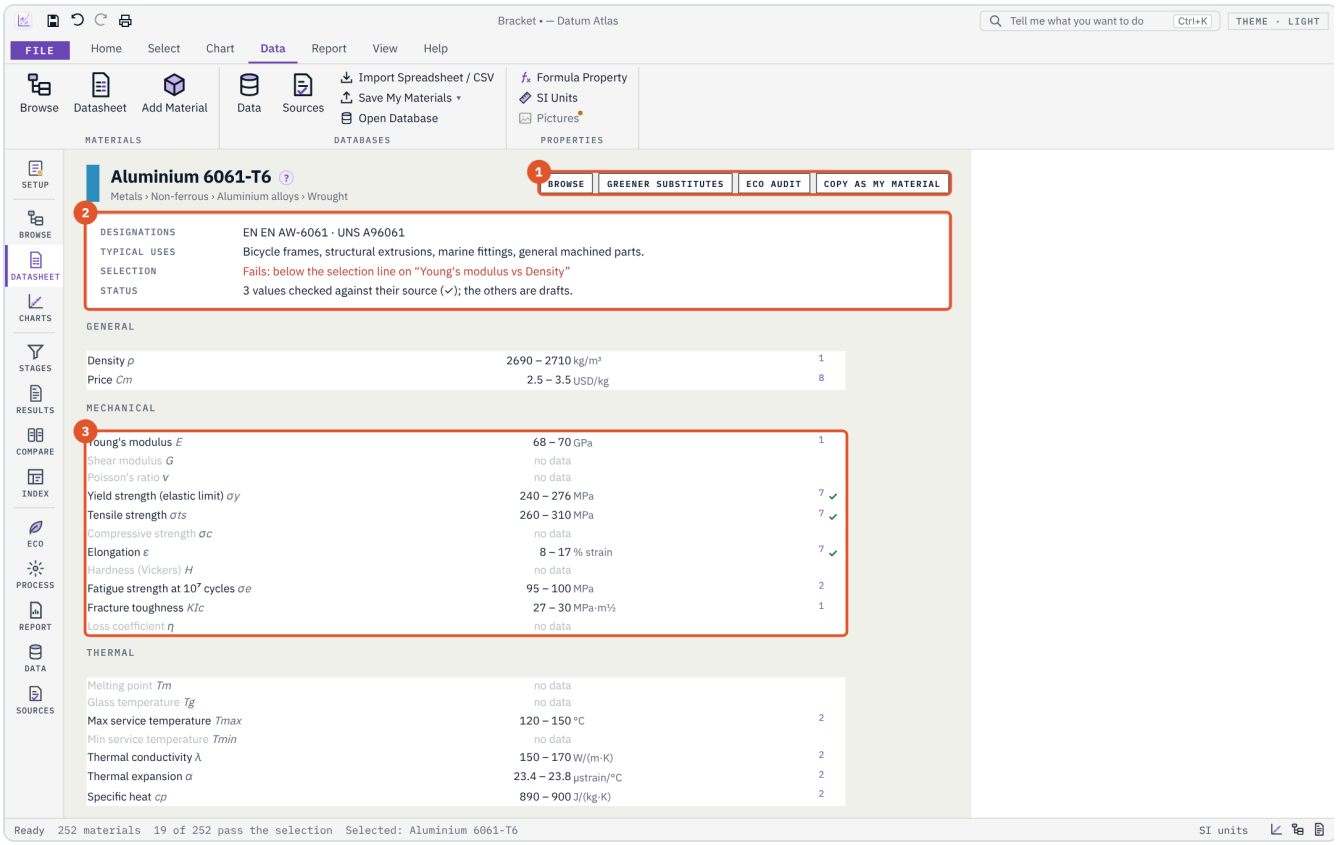
Below them, every material that fails says why: *below the selection line on "Young's modulus vs Density"*, *price above 20 USD/kg*, *no data for max service temperature*. **+ compare** adds a material to Compare. **Select › To a Spreadsheet** saves the whole table (rank, index, × best, the values the selection uses, the reasons) as `.xlsx`; **Report › Results as CSV** as `.csv`.

Browse, datasheets and sources



Browse: the family tree and the materials table.

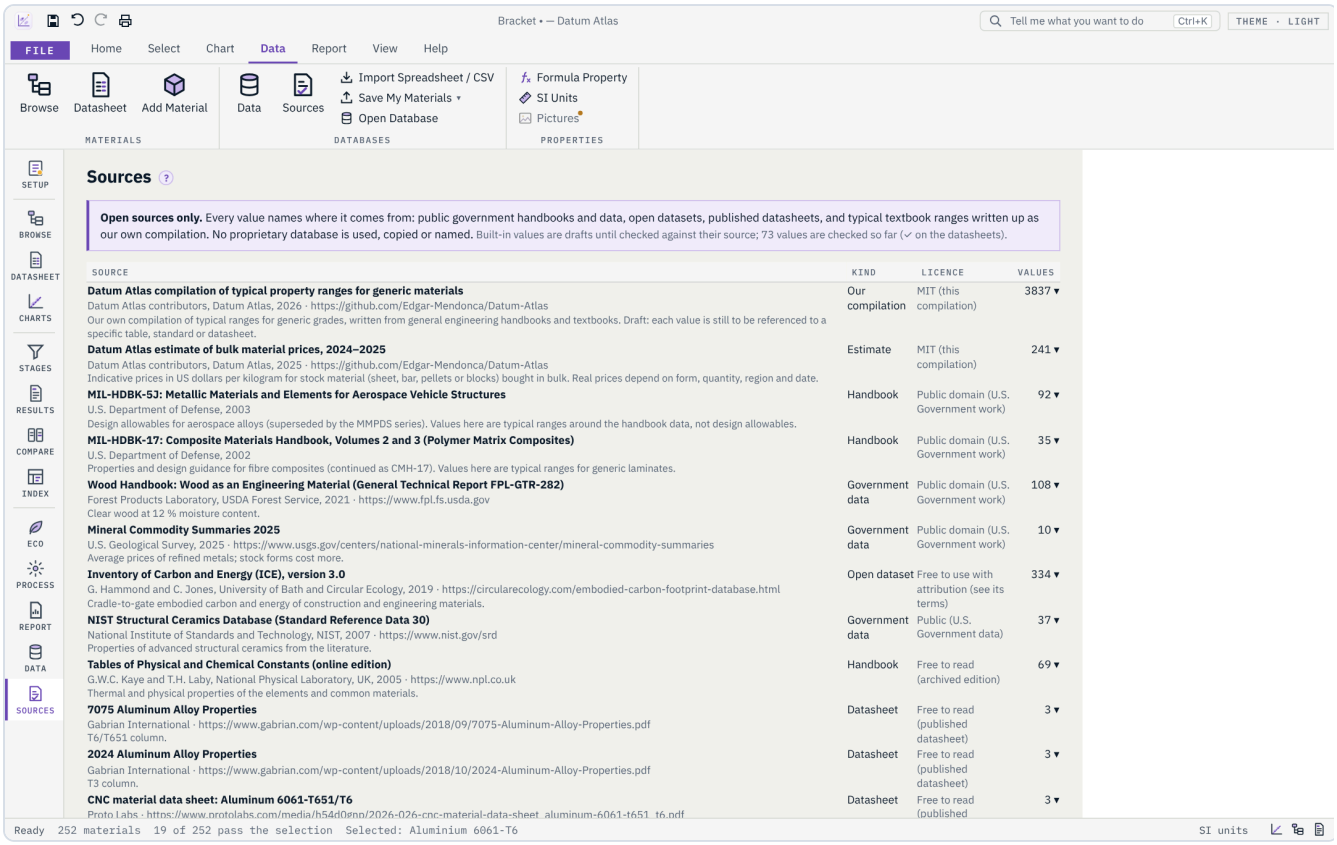
1. **The family tree.** Click a family or class to show only its materials.
2. **Search** by name, designation (UNS, EN, JIS, ASTM), family or use.
3. **The table.** Sort by any heading; choose the columns; select cells, rows or columns and copy them (`Ctrl+C`) into a spreadsheet. `Enter` opens the datasheet.



A datasheet: the facts, every value with its source, and the references.

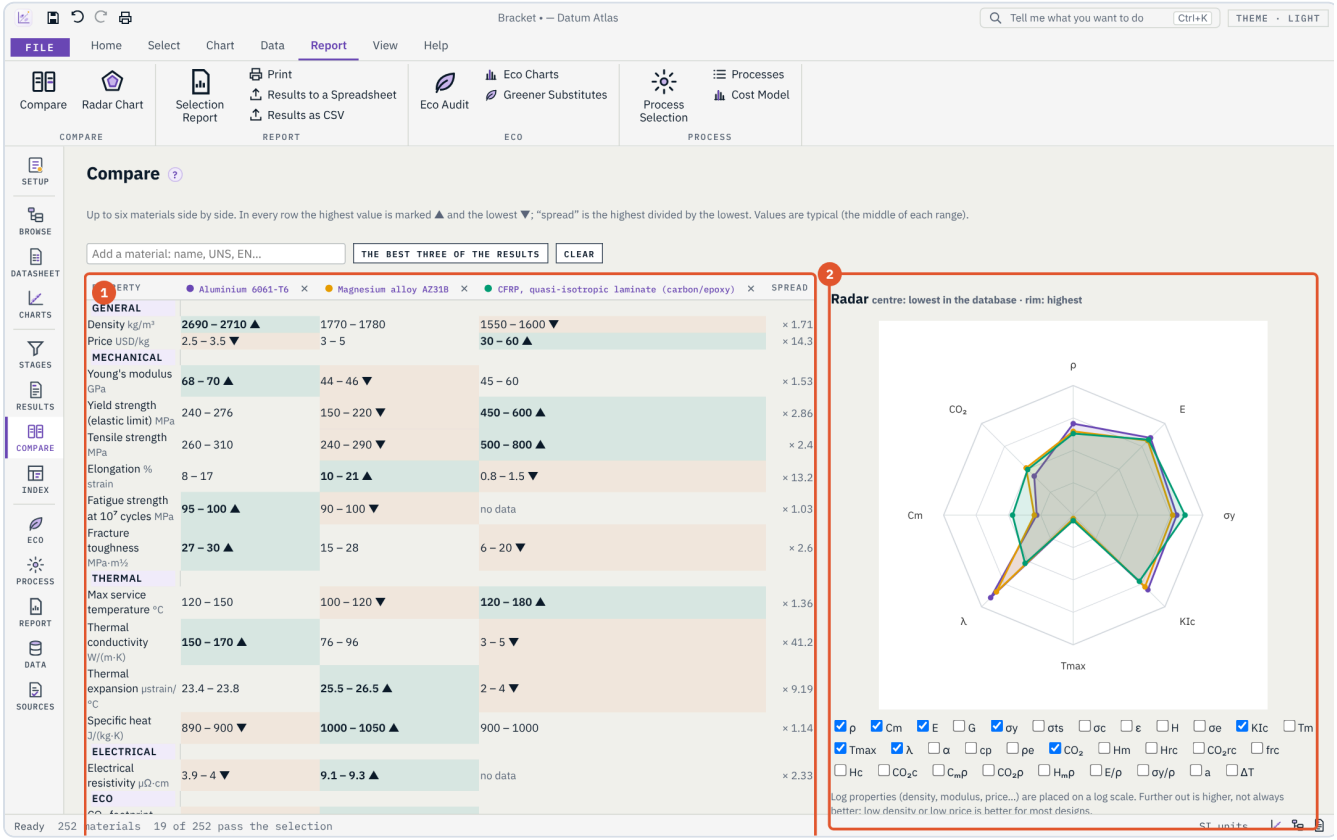
1. **Greener substitutes**, **Eco audit** (adds it to the audit) and **Copy as my material**.
2. **The facts:** designations, other names, typical uses, notes, how it fares in the selection, and its status (draft, or how many values were checked).
3. **The values**, grouped (general, mechanical, thermal, electrical, durability, processing, eco, derived), each with its unit and the number of its reference; ✓ marks a checked value; *no data* is a gap.

The references at the bottom give each source: its title, publisher, year, licence and link. The **Sources** page lists every source, its kind and licence; click one to see which materials and values cite it.



Sources: open and public sources only.

Compare

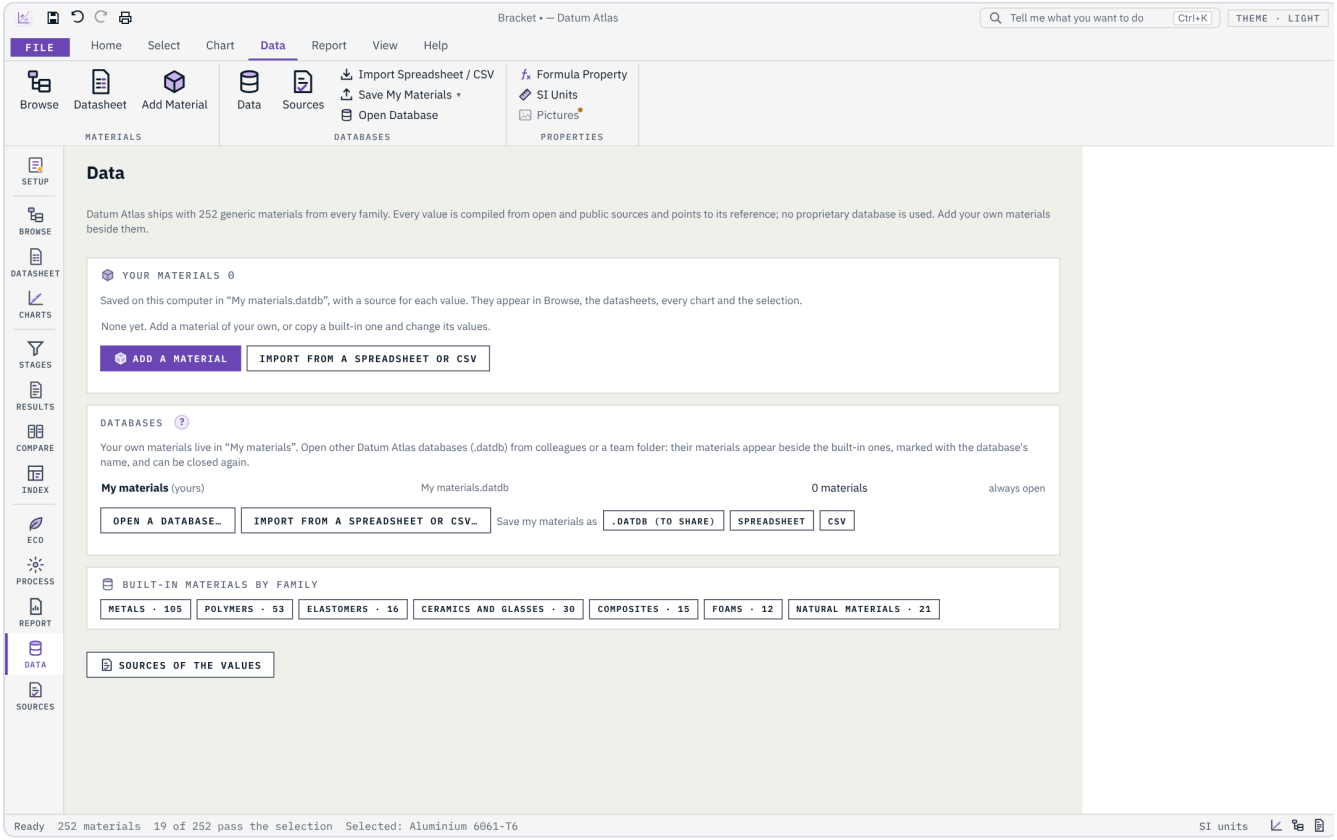


Compare: three materials side by side, and the radar chart.

1. **The table.** Up to six materials, property by property: the highest of each row is marked ▲ and the lowest ▼, and **spread** is the highest divided by the lowest.
2. **The radar chart.** Each material's outline, each property placed between the lowest (centre) and the highest (rim) value in the whole database. Tick the properties to show. Further out is higher, not always better: low density or low price is better for most designs.

Add materials with the box at the top, from Results (**+ compare**), from the card beside the chart, or **The best three of the results**.

Your own materials and databases

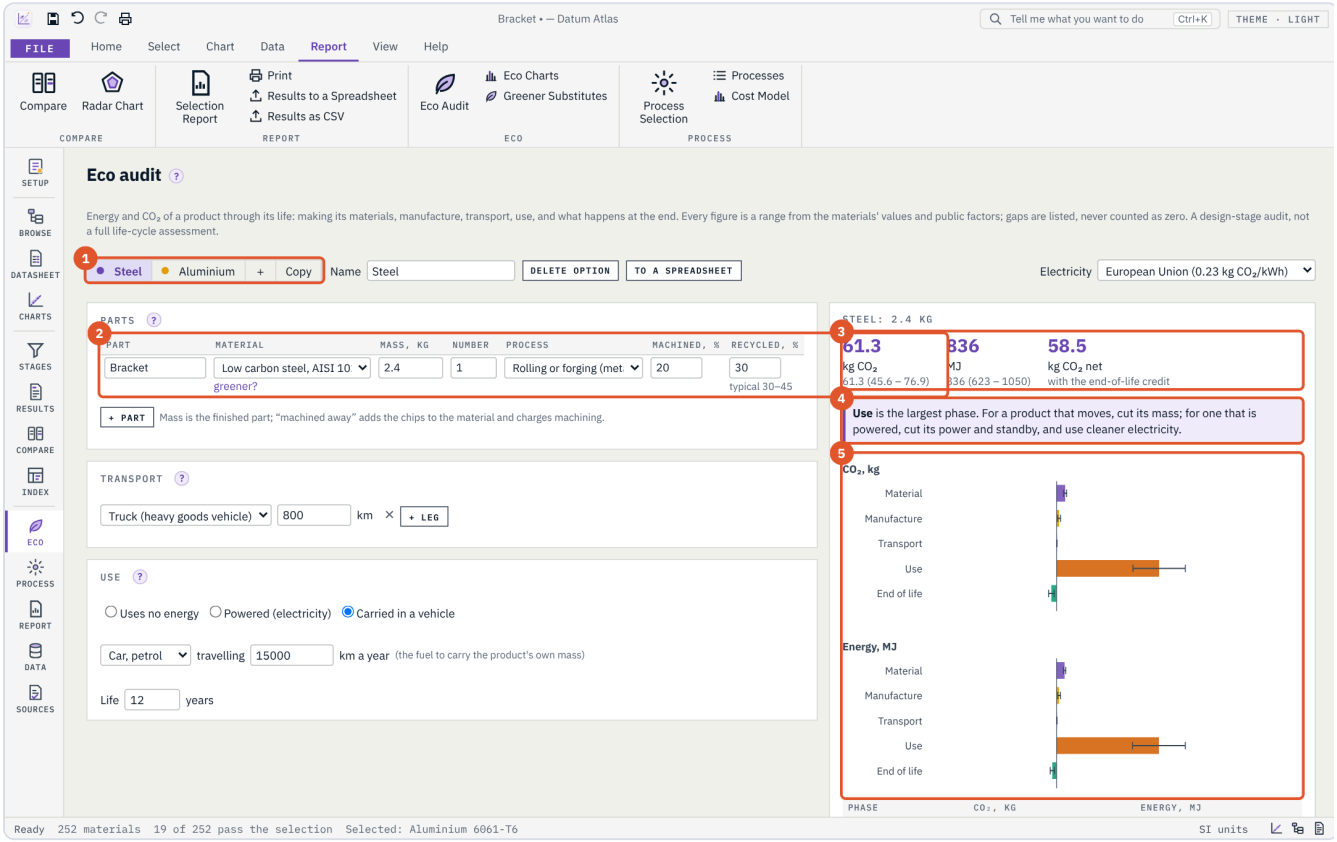


Data: your materials, databases, families and properties.

- **Add Material** opens a form that says what is needed: a name, the family, density, at least one more property, the low and high of each value in the unit shown, and where the values come from (a book, a datasheet, a test report or your own measurement).
- **Import Spreadsheet / CSV** reads a table: each column is matched to a property by its heading (change any that are wrong); a cell may hold one value or a range (2690 – 2710); headings in imperial units are converted. You see the rows before they are added, and values that cannot be used are listed, never added as zero.
- **Open Database** opens another `.datdb` (a colleague's, a team folder's) beside the built-in data; its materials are marked with its name and can be closed again.
- **Save My Materials** writes your materials as a `.datdb` to share, a spreadsheet or CSV.

The eco audit

The eco audit adds up the energy and CO_2 of a product through its life: making its materials, manufacture, transport, use and the end of its life. It shows which phase matters most, so you know where a change helps.



The eco audit of a bracket: parts, totals, the largest phase and the phase bars.

1. **Design options.** Up to four versions of the product; **Copy** one to change one thing (another material, a lighter design).
2. **Parts.** Each part's material, finished mass and number; its process; the share **machined** away (it adds to the material bought and charges machining); its **recycled** content (the typical share of today's supply is shown); and its **end of life**: landfill, burn for energy, downcycle, recycle or not counted.
3. **The totals:** CO_2 and energy for the first four phases, with their ranges, and the net CO_2 with the end-of-life credit.
4. **The largest phase**, and what usually helps for it.
5. **The phase bars**, CO_2 and energy, each with its range.

Below the parts, **Transport** takes legs by sea, rail, road or air with their distances, and **Use** is either **Powered** (kW, hours a day, days a year, on the electricity grid chosen at the top) or **Carried in a vehicle** (the fuel to carry the product's own mass, for the distance travelled a year), for a life in years.

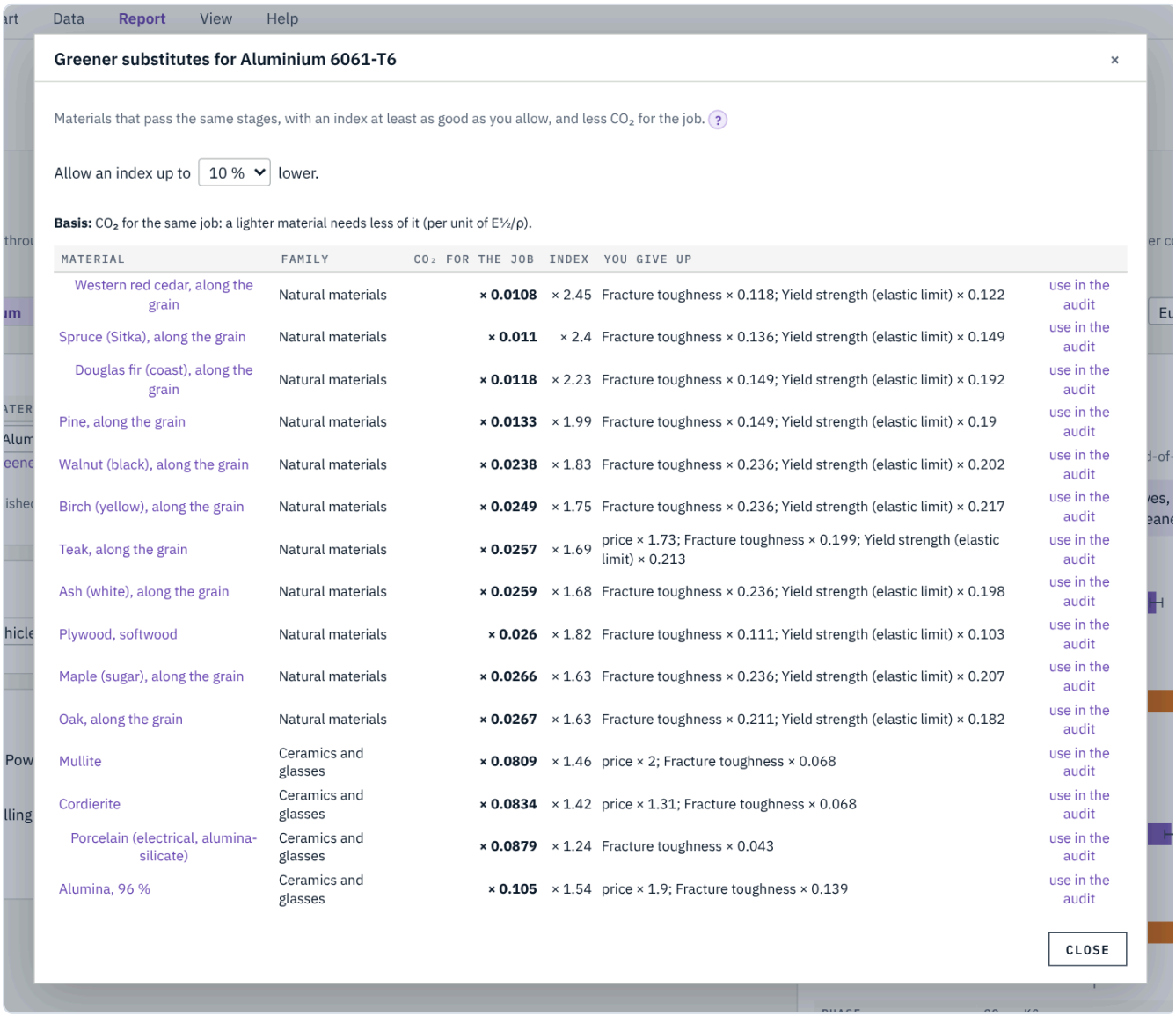


Two options side by side: where a lighter design pays back.

With two or more options, **Options side by side** compares them phase by phase, and the chart draws each option's CO_2 against years of use: what it costs to make is where its line starts, and the use phase is its slope. Where the lines cross, the options **break even**.

Every figure is a range from the values' own ranges and public factors (freight, vehicles, electricity in eleven countries and regions, process energy). A material without a value is listed in the notes, never counted as zero. This is a design-stage audit, not a full life-cycle assessment. The audit goes into the report, and **To a spreadsheet** saves every option, phase and part.

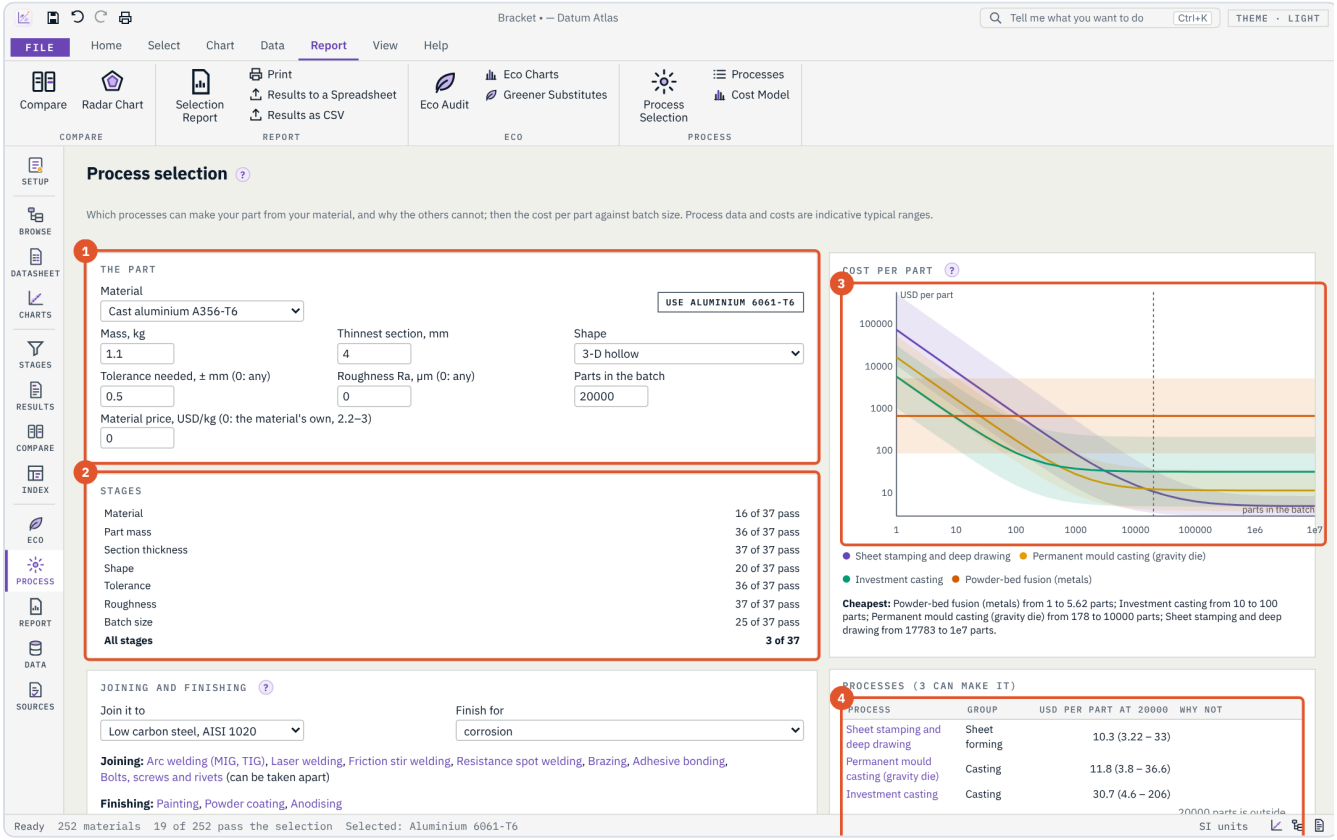
Greener substitutes



Greener substitutes for the aluminium bracket.

Greener substitutes (from a datasheet, the ribbon or **greener?** beside an audit part) lists materials that pass the same stages, with an index nearly as good (you choose how much lower is allowed), and less CO_2 **for the same job**. With a minimum-mass index such as E½/ρ, a better index means less material, so CO_2 for the job is CO_2 per kilogram divided by the index. **You give up** lists price and properties at least 20 % worse. **Use in the audit** swaps the part's material.

Process selection

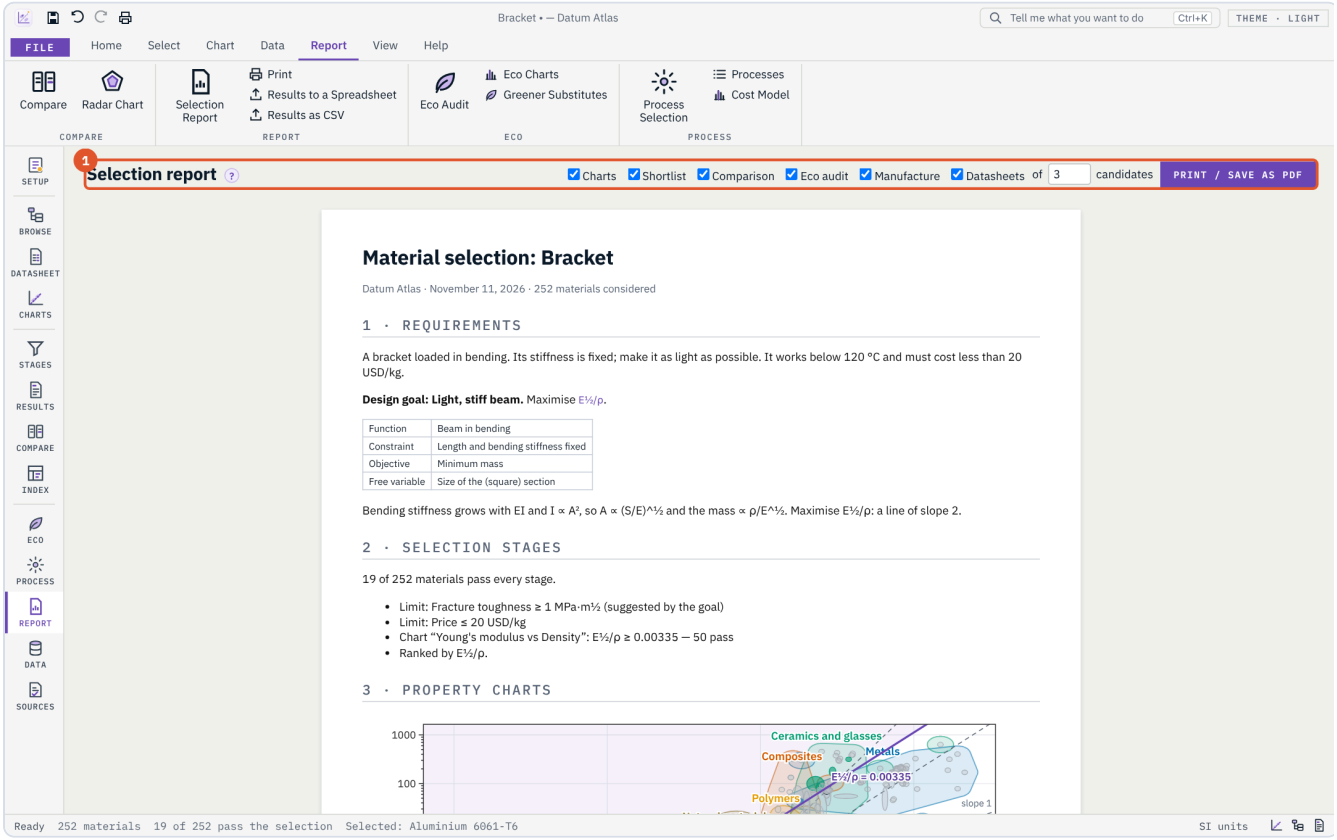


Process selection for a cast aluminium part.

1. **The part:** its material (or **Use …** for the one picked on a chart), mass, thinnest section, shape (flat, sheet, prismatic, 3-D solid, 3-D hollow), the tolerance and surface roughness it needs, the number of parts, and the material price (0 uses the material's own).
2. **Stages:** how many of the processes pass each requirement, and all of them.
3. **Cost per part** against batch size, on log axes: material (with what is wasted) + tooling shared over the batch + the machine's hourly cost divided by its rate. Tooling makes small batches dear; where the curves cross, the cheapest process changes, and the line below the chart says which is cheapest for which batch sizes. The dashed line is your batch size.
4. **Processes:** those that can make the part first, cheapest first; every other one says what stops it (*does not work this alloy*, *cannot make a 3-D hollow part*, *its best tolerance is ±0.8 mm*, *outside its economic batch*).

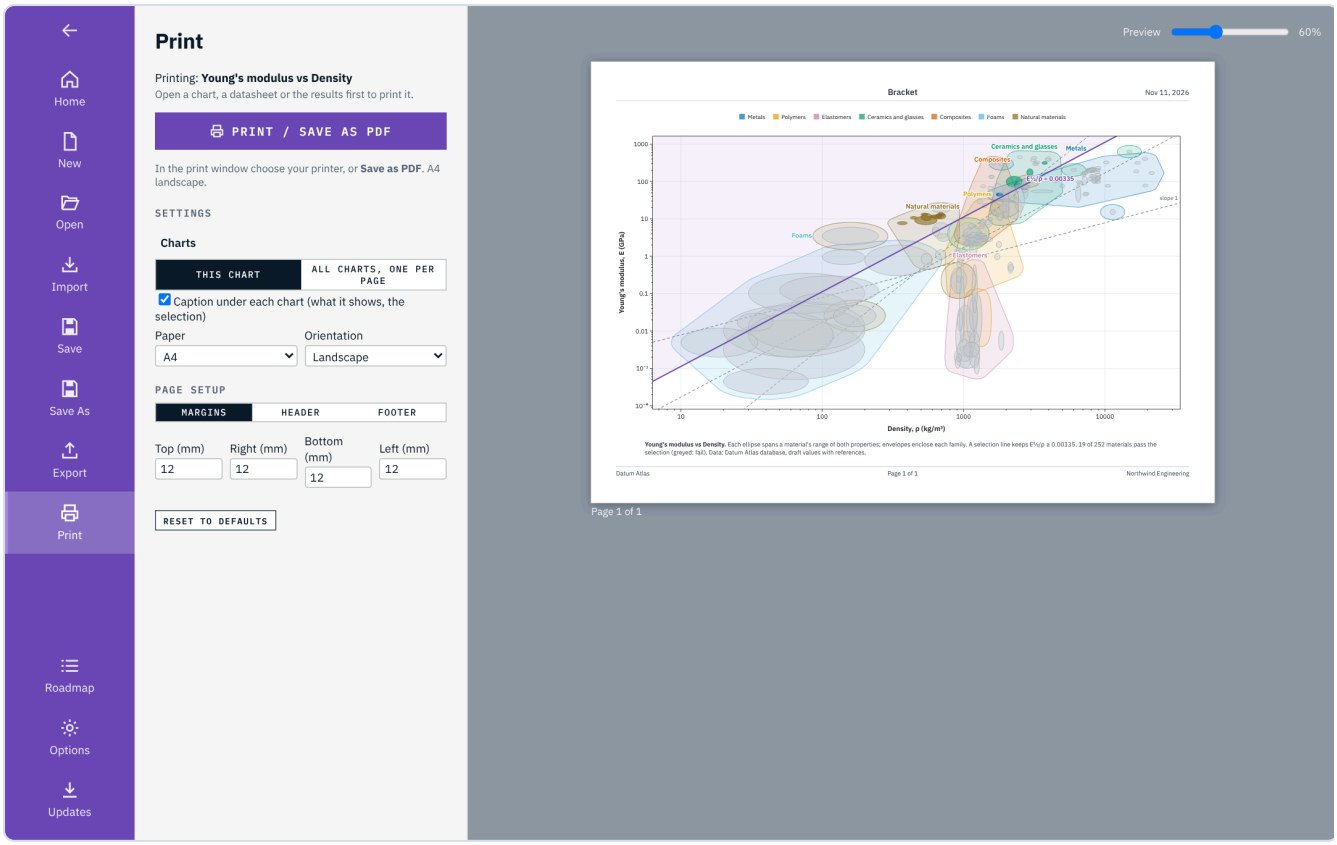
Below them: **Joining and finishing** lists ways to join the material to itself or to another, and finishes for what you need (corrosion, wear, decoration…); **Processes for the shortlist** shows which processes work the materials in Compare or the best of the results. **Report › Processes** lists every process record; click one for its card. Process data and costs are indicative typical ranges, not quotes: ask your supplier.

The report, printing and export



The selection report.

1. Choose what the report holds: the requirements and the design goal, the stages, the **charts**, the **shortlist**, the **comparison**, the **eco audit**, the **manufacture**, and the **datasheets** of the best candidates with their sources. **Print / Save as PDF** prints it.



File › Print, with the preview.

File › Print (`Ctrl+P`) prints the open chart (vector, with its legend and a caption), a datasheet, the results or the report, with page setup, margins, headers and footers. Choose **Save as PDF** in the print window for a PDF.

Other ways out:

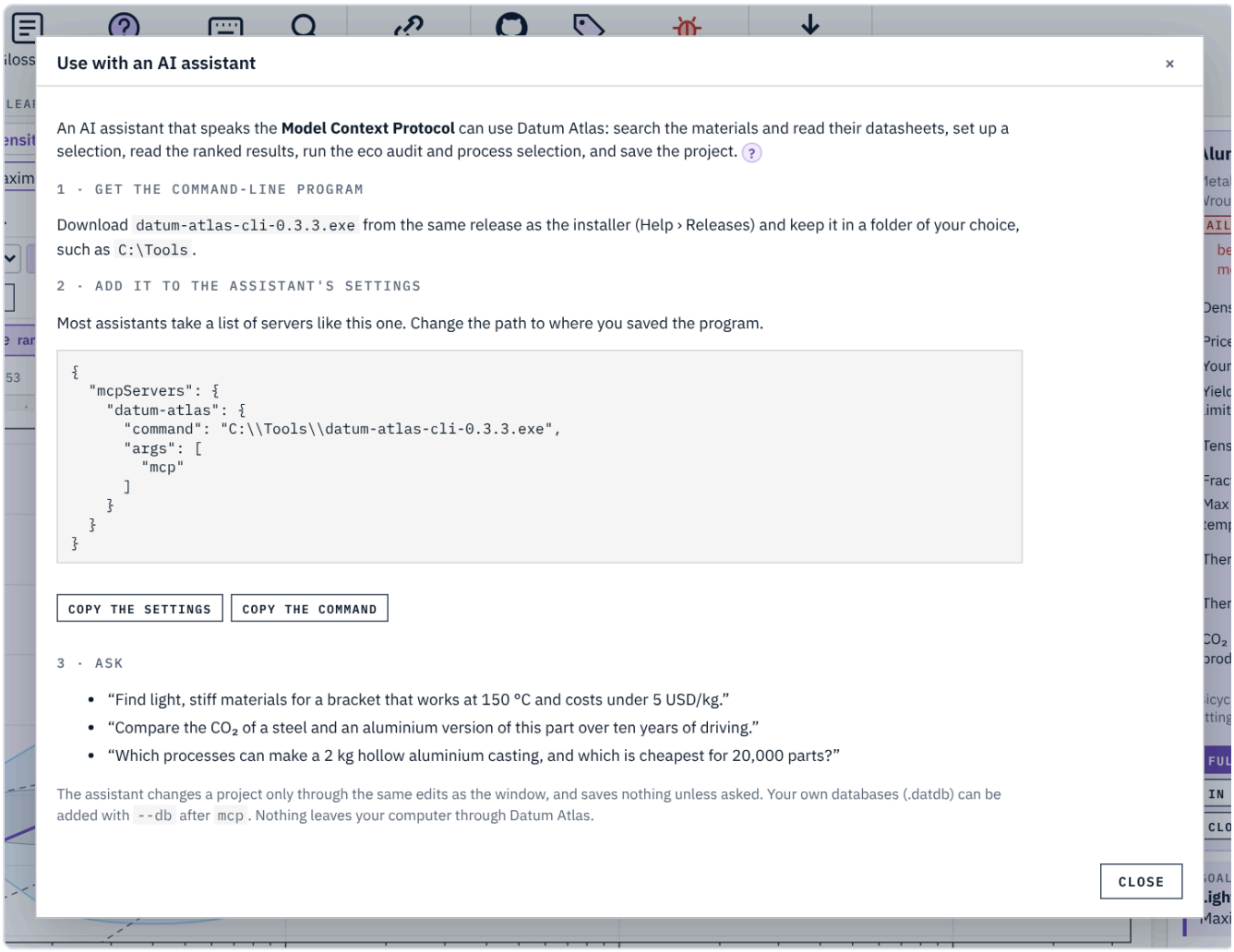
- **Chart › Export:** the chart as SVG (sharp at any size) or PNG (at the resolution in Options). **Copy Picture** puts it on the clipboard for a document or a slide.
- **Results** and the **eco audit** as `.xlsx` or `.csv`.
- **Your materials** as `.datdb`, `.xlsx` or `.csv`.

The command line and AI assistants

Every release has a small program beside the installer, `datum-atlas-cli-x.y.z.exe`. It does what the window does, from a command prompt:

Command	What it does
`search 6061`	Materials by name, designation or use
`material al-6061-t6`	A datasheet: values, units, sources, ✓
`new beam bracket.datlas`	Start a project from a design problem
`results bracket.datlas --csv`	Every material ranked, and why the others fail
`ops`	The named edits, each with an example
`apply bracket.datlas --op '…' --save new.datlas`	Change a project with a named edit
`eco`, `process`, `substitutes`	The eco audit, process selection, greener substitutes
`export bracket.datlas results.xlsx`	Save as .datlas, .xlsx or .csv

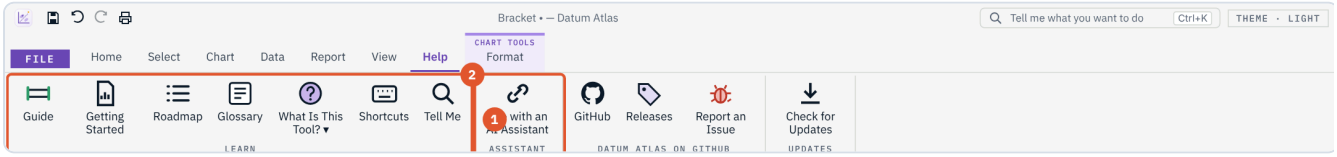
`--db mine.datdb` adds a database of your own. Nothing is saved unless you say `--save` or `export`.



Help › Use with an AI Assistant.

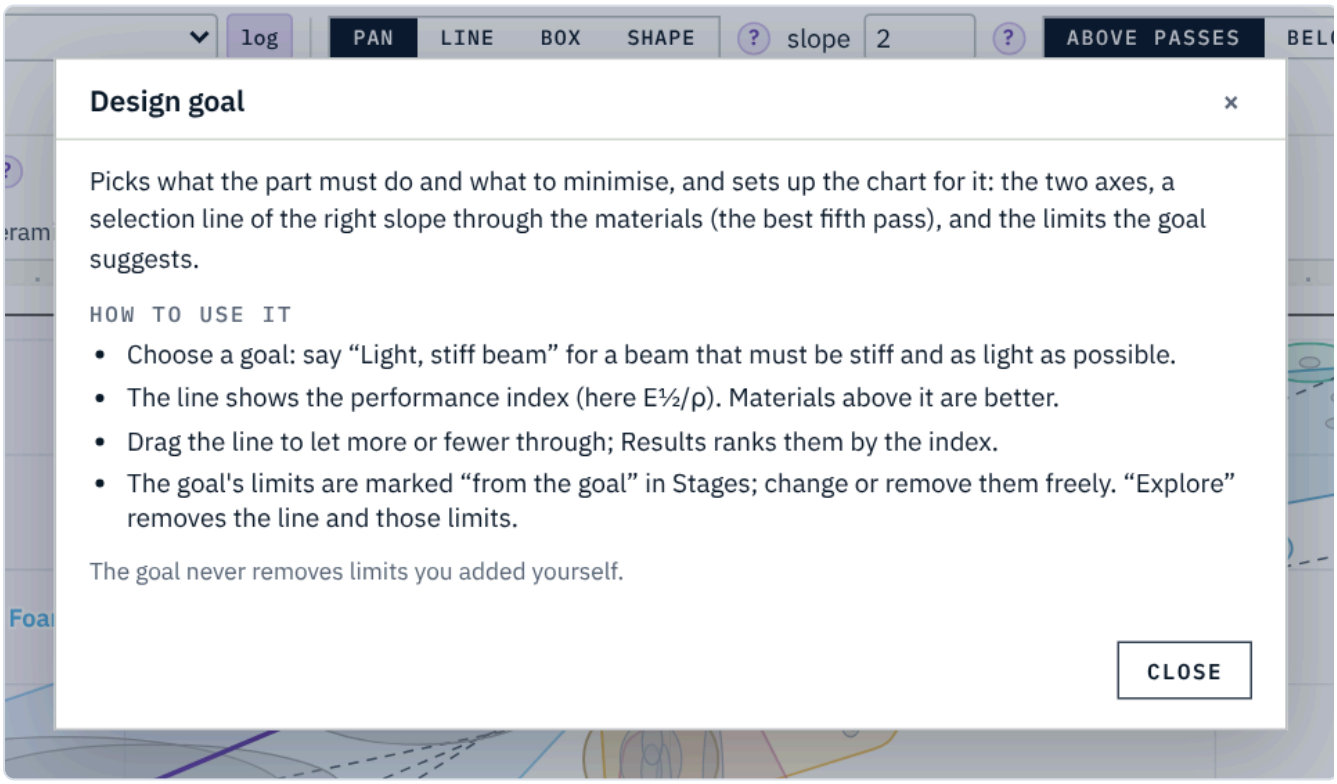
`datum-atlas-cli mcp` connects an AI assistant that speaks the Model Context Protocol. The assistant can search the materials and read their datasheets, set up a selection with the same edits as the window, read the ranked results, run the eco audit and process selection, and save the project when you ask. **Help › Use with an AI Assistant** has the settings to copy into the assistant.

Help, options and shortcuts



The Help tab.

1. **Learn: Getting Started** (the method in one page), **Roadmap** (what each coming release brings), **Glossary** (bubble, envelope, index, × best, life phases, economic batch… with a search box), **What Is This Tool?** (every ? card), **Shortcuts** and **Tell Me**.
2. **Assistant:** how to connect an AI assistant.



A ? card.

File › Options: the theme (light, dark, or auto with Windows), SI or imperial units, autosave every few minutes, labels and guide lines on new charts, the picture resolution, paper size and orientation, and your company name and logo for printed pages.

Keys	What they do
`Ctrl+K` or `Alt+Q`	Tell Me: find a command, a goal or a material
`Ctrl+N` `Ctrl+O` `Ctrl+S`	New (File › Home), open, save
`Ctrl+Shift+S`	Save As
`Ctrl+P`	Print

Keys	What they do
`Ctrl+Z` `Ctrl+Y`	Undo, redo
Wheel, drag	Zoom and pan the chart
Arrow keys	Move the active selection line (`Shift`: ten times further)
`Ctrl+C`	Copy the selected table cells
`F1`	Keyboard shortcuts

If Datum Atlas closes before you save, it offers to recover your work the next time it starts.

> **Tip.** Report a problem or ask for a feature with **Help › Report an Issue**. Corrections to a value, with a reference, are welcome.